

The Voice Express

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FEATURES

Misogyny, Treason, and Plot: Notes from the Cockroaches’ Long Night of Short Knives

A law graduate's account of the 20 July protest against Dharmendra Pradhan at Jantar Mantar: the Delhi Police's lathi charges and a near-fatal stampede, and the protective patriarchy of the men who decided where women belonged.

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As a political student, activist, researcher, future advocate, an officer of the court and what have you, who has been protesting almost ceaselessly since 2023, the Jantar Mantar protest site has over the years been to me akin to a second home.

Through the years of my higher education, between home (in the more traditional sense) and university, Jantar Mantar became my most frequented haunt in Delhi, where I was born and have lived all my still (hopefully) nascent life. From my college in the outskirts of NCR, I’d make the hours-long journey inward every weekend for a new cause: sometimes for women’s issues, sometimes over the Labour Codes, sometimes for political prisoners’ release; over land grabs and corporate loot, against unjust laws and for more just ones... all things civil and political.

Sometimes, I would hang around with comrades over suttas and chai to kill time before our demonstrations began, then go help set up shop or wait for the inordinate 1-hour delay. The anatomy of the student protest has a simple and predictable design: slogan, speeches and song, underscored by that feeling of camaraderie and togetherness with people one may have “antagonistic or non-antagonistic” contradictions with.

This is particularly true of Jantar Mantar protests, the ones within the demarcated protest elsewhere, we’d almost certainly be immediately dragged and detained without warning, sometimes “kindly” (as kind as you can perceive the police to be while they are dragging you off of public sites of resistance and passivity). The detained evenings would be spent in some far-off police station at the very border of the city (Bawana, Kapashera, Narela being favourites of the Delhi Police in terms of remoteness) and then wait till the night, when we would exert enough pressure to all be “allowed” to leave.

In the period of 3 and a half years I’ve been around student activist spaces, I’ve observed detentions and the threats thereof to have become much more frequent and brutal. So much so that for a point in time, it even became impossible to protest in the real senses of the word. To protest in a public site would mean a sea of bureaucracy in terms of getting permission (or choosing not to) and mobilising, only to prepare for the almost definite eventuality of detention. On the better days, when the protest of the week occurred as intended rather than being dramatically yet unceremoniously shelved thanks to someone or the other being “detained out of sight”, I’d spend my evenings reading, discussing and strategising with “comrades”.

My romance with so-called progressive student and political organisations, sordid and sensational, ended in justifiable estrangement on my side: After speaking out on what have now become my well-contentified experiences in the organised left, I faced still more patriarchal violence (sexual, physical), debasement (even from those groups that seemingly took an anti-rape stance “for” me) and determined, relentless, and passionate slander that continues to follow me to this day. But through all that and past it, my relationship with protest never ended, neither within my university (which thankfully, I recently graduated from), nor outside it. I remained vocal in the civil and political rights arenas, and showed up to protests nonetheless to the best of my ability.

The protest against Dharmendra Pradhan on 20th July, called for by CJP and other associated organisations/groups, in this context, was markedly distinct from any other I’ve been a part of at Jantar Mantar till date, so much so that I felt it deserved my intellectual consideration beyond its political demands and strategic deconstruction. 20th July was unique in two key ways: First, the broader mass-based demands and outreach (as well as relatively lesser state-repression on a demand that struck the hearts of the “educated middle class”) meant the potential to grow into a mass movement, as opposed to smaller, much repressed, seldom permitted left-protests I’d most often participated in. Second, in the overt misogyny I encountered at the site of protest, making me reconsider the mass-movement’s own understanding of its women constituents and their struggles.

On the day of the protest, I left home around 7am, though the protest was beginning at 9.

The Indian State, which routinely shows up with batons, 20 or so “riot control” (detention) buses, and hundreds of police personnel to ostensibly secure protests by left-leaning organisations that optimistically gather downwards of 50 odd students on average, was more than satisfactorily prepared for the hordes of people who showed up to the call, students from across disciplines from all over the country, youngsters preparing for competitive exams, members of other ongoing resistances showing solidarity, job-goers, and everyone in between; an unusual combination of men, women, and quite a lot of children (from toddlers to teenagers) in the mood for revolt. It was so well-prepared in fact, that all routes to Jantar Mantar were blocked by the morning.

As I walked the winding roads into the heart of Central Delhi toward the protest site (having taken an auto as far as it would go), I started getting calls from friends and comrades telling me that exits had been closed at the

I was supposed to be at the protest with a few other women who were there for the first time, not to the Jantar Mantar protest site, but to any protest at all. They’d indeed picked an interesting and unforgettable one for their first.

I told my friends to meet me at Bangla Sahib, and from there we walked, following the maps we had (fortunately) downloaded ahead of time. Cellular networks had, of course, already been suspended in the area, rendering our phones virtually useless.

When my friends expressed shock at the internet shutdown, my internal (and partly external) monologue was fraught with cynicism: Of course, this had happened. Did the people of India not realise that just as the State had been doing for years in Kashmir, Manipur and other parts of the country, push come to shove, it wouldn’t refrain from doing anywhere and everywhere else, even the national capital? It wouldn’t refrain from, say, shutting down the internet when it came to masses gathering at Jantar Mantar, however protected the educated, white-collared sections of those masses of New Delhi may think themselves to be?!

I would find myself mentally revisiting this retort all through the day, as the State reminded us that the National Capital, indeed, was not immune to its usual fascistic war machinery designed to be utilised against its own citizens: 12-gauge ‘pellet’ shotguns, chemical warfare, and lathi charges included. But my retorting voice, of course, grew weaker as the day progressed, coughing through walls of tear gas, ill-advisedly rubbing my eyes before washing them clean, or comforting a bleeding friend.

I realised, slowly, over the day, that my unique experience in the group of being both accustomed and limited to spaces of Marxist-Leninist activism had made me “used to” police violence, normalised it in my mind as something that does happen all the time, and happens worse where the cameras are systematically never pointed, more on that later, whilst simultaneously leaving me unprepared for it

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Allow me to explain: I'd been at the receiving end of police lathis before, been detained earlier, and marched despite orders not to march by the authorities. (After all, should a protest against an authoritarian, fascist state be done with its permission?)

While fear was a slight ember flickering now and then through these dog days; the fuel of ideological commitment and belief in my comrades allowed me to be certain that even if I weren't to be safe, were to be arrested, there would be people standing for me, as I would for them. My experiences with the left in the past year or two (which will be briefly elucidated upon in the second half) made me realise that perhaps not everyone is in the same struggle, for the same reasons and with the same incentives.

Further, as part of my ideological "upbringing" I'd led myself to believe and had been led to believe that with my "privilege" at least public protest would not be a site of death for me (bodily harm, I was fine with as a cost to pay for resistance). My estrangement with the organised left and the realisation that I may as well have been wrong in my latter supposition was a big wake-up call.

On 20th July, months after this estrangement, I was not prepared for the events of the day. As it unfolded on myself and others, the Delhi police's brutality on 20 July 2026 took me wholly by surprise.

We broke two-three barricades and were at the front of the crowd nearing Parliament Street, when the first direct confrontation with the police happened. The anti-riot squad stood in line faced towards us, lathis in their hands, their "anti-riot" shields up, helmet-visors drawn; we found ourselves unable to push past. So, we sat on the ground in front of them while we tried to figure out how to proceed. This was right in front of a line of barricades we'd just crossed, sandwiched between them and the State's hired, official goons blocking our way, decked in full, militant glory. For good measure, I could also see two water-cannon wielding truck-like vehicles and several police buses blocking the route ahead by sporadically being placed across the middle and both sides of the oncoming road.

The police began lathi-charge. Everyone seated got up in a flurry. I reached to grab the hands of both the comrades I was with, assuming the crowd would use its inertia to push ahead past the attacking police. But, the police pushed us behind, by brute force, and the crowd behind pushed zealously ahead. Those of us at the front, pushed in both directions, and closely sequestered into a few spaces, started falling.

I used my quick-mindedness and memory from past lathi-charges to quickly take off my glasses and hand them one of the women with me, the message (I hoped) apparent: "Don't let them break, I am blind without them." Then, I felt my feet shifting against my will, just as I was twisting back to grab my friend's hand. I fell down, and a stampede erupted around me. My nose pushed into the road; everything around me went black.

I could hear people shouting above, I felt the air escape my lungs and I felt myself struggling to breathe. For a milli-second, a thought flashed into my head, a feeling of terror I haven't been able to shake away still: "I am going to die in a stampede at Jantar Mantar." The next second I started screaming for help, bloody murder, English-Hindi a mix, hoping that someone would pull me out. I'd been stuck in semi-stampede situations caused by police at protests while they attempted to detain peaceful protesters before, but never a stampede-like attack where I thought I'd actually die. Eventually, someone heard my cries and pulled me out.

Eventually, somehow, this crowd made its way past this first lathi-charge into the second, which happened right outside the LIC Bank building, a few steps behind the Parliament Street Police Station, and a few steps in front of the old court building. Here, I was separated from my friends, and faced a lathi charge alone, after getting stuck beneath two bikes at the side pavement while trying to escape another Delhi-police orchestrated stampede.

This was the first lesson I learnt that day: my experience as an activist who's seen police brutality as a normal, everyday aspect of life, be it as a student, as a citizen or as an aspiring lawyer who works on prisoners' rights, had in fact served only to desensitise me from the reality of it.

This is not to say that police brutality is not a normal, everyday truth. Let me tell you that police brutality is omnipresent in our justice system. It gets worse, deadly and much less reported or even recognised when the ones at the receiving end are not educated, financially privileged, caste-Hindu, rights-knowing student activists. But as such, somewhere, I'd come to not only see it as a given cost of protesting, of speaking up in a State that is undoubtedly fascist, but also accept it.

Beyond the cynicism towards the protesting "middle class", the caste-Hindus who showed up when it came to them, but never against fascism the many, many times that it's been mutinied against in this very city (the Farmers' Protest, the CAA-NRC movement, the longstanding demands for NTA-NEP's demolition or the implementation of the Manual Scavenging Act or the Rohith Act), or even the leadership of this protest that distanced itself from student political prisoners such as Umar or Sharjeel that I'd carried with me on the morning of the 20th, I felt something else.

If every one of us who took the streets that day, some for the first time, saw the violent realities of this State firsthand as I had, I wondered if we might still come to stand against violence elsewhere and everywhere. The cynicism I'd internalised due to my particular experiences in the left began to feel misguided. I felt, after a long time, optimistic.

I felt hope.

The second distinguishing factor I experienced in the protest was the inescapable, evident, suffocating (way more so than the literal suffocation of the crowd) patriarchy.

Now, I am no stranger to patriarchy in places one imagines would be "better", "less patriarchal", "less violent" to women.(I say "less" instead of "non" deliberately, I was aware that patriarchy is plaguing our society, economically and socially, to the extent that to fight it is to recognise its existence in everything, and hence, I didn't expect it to be absent in a left space that has historically done a lot but never enough in its struggle against patriarchy) My own experience as a woman has proved to me that political spaces mobilising for emancipation of all kinds, too, are hotbeds of the culture they purport to hope to destroy. That the same pervasiveness that misogyny enjoys in a woman's public life (university, profession, navigation of public spaces) and her so-called "private" life (family, partnerships, friendships), it enjoys in her political life: as an activist, as a member of an organisation, or as a citizen rising up against the State.

That being said, one fundamental experience I'd had as part of ML spaces was that of the spatial liberation they offered: from having comrades to stand by me if I left home as an adult woman at times or for periods my family deemed undesirable, to the very public act of protest itself. Occupying space as a citizen, from within my university to Jantar Mantar, spaces that have traditionally been denied to women, making speeches, sloganeering loudly, shouting and coming face to face with the literal armed forces of the State, are not challenges to Indian women's participation in the left, but incentives for it . And though the so-called "comrades" of liberal-progressive inheritance, male and female, may be patriarchal, may indeed be rapists or rape-enablers (an expansion of this is the subject of another essay, for another time), when we come to protests, be they at Jantar Mantar or anywhere else, we are equals. Men and women, in the "leftist" public space, are equals.

In fact, it is often the women and the AFAB (Assigned Female at Birth) comrades who are gathering up in chains at the front of the mass during detentions and lathi-charges, it is them who are at the forefront of resistance. Representation-wise, too, although left groups struggle with having women substantively occupy leadership, they play the numbers game well. Most protests I've gone to where students have been the majority protesters, the number of men to women is staggering at 50/50, give or take, and rarely is there a substantive under-representation of the latter.

That itself says a lot, for it takes innumerable fights with various forces that contend to control an adult woman's life (but yes, the primary force in this case, is family) to even have women students venture out of their homes if not for "justifiable" reasons (college classes, tuitions, jobs). There, facing the threat of police violence (beatings, detentions, arrests) and moreover, doing so with the spectre of your family creeping closer, perhaps as the detention extends past 6 pm (illegally), and you are left dodging calls... It is indeed one commendable act of the left, that it provides a space for women as part of the organisation, the university, the citizenry, the publically raging mass, as part of the collective. (This liberatory aspect is evidently contradictory to its own misogyny, my analysis? Protest operates as theatre, a political performance, where gender contradictions are put aside by all parties for a while, for the "larger cause". The "equality" isn't a complete lie, it is materially orchestrated and meaningful, yet it isn't the full reality either. It hides the tensions "behind the scenes".)

I remember, as a young woman of 19, I first frequented Delhi roads past midnight while wall-painting with a political organisation. As a young, sheltered girl, the left was my material escape into freedom: with years of ideology, reading circles, organising and engaging with many different groups I grew confident to handle myself in public spaces that are inherently anti-woman.

Every woman knows that the public sphere is not for us. We are taught that very early in our girlhood: "It is not safe for you to go out alone," in certain localities, at certain times. We learn to avoid dark streets, isolated areas, lone treks. We learn not to loiter, not to be out in a public space unless we need to. (Because why would you expose yourself to possibilities of violence when you don't "have to"?) Public transport is inaccessible, though many of us don't have a choice. We have gotten well-accustomed to stares, catcalls and lecherous or (on a lucky day) judgemental glances being thrown our way on every street we walk through. Strangers anywhere can approach and at best, morally police (and at worst, batter, rape, and kill us). The people we know, within the localities we frequent, may be just as much of a threat.

If none of this prevails upon you as a woman frequenting a public space in a day, maybe you'll be familiar instead with the benevolent version of this patriarchy: "Well-meaning" men, sometimes women, coming upon you, informing you it's not safe to go this or that way at this or that time, asking you personal questions, commenting benevolently on how your dress or way of walking, way of sitting is inappropriate, etc. The infringement never ends.

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With this reality, protests were comparative safe spaces to me so far. At least within a protest, I believed, those fighting for the same cause as me would not expose me, or other women, to that sort of patriarchy, at least not till the third act ends and the curtains fall. So imagine my surprise, on 20th July, when as I negotiated with the police along with other men and women on the “back end” of the protest site, to “allow” us to enter the designated area of protest, I heard a group of men commenting, “ Kaafi ladkiyan aayi hai protest mei. ” (“ A lot of girls seem to have come to this protest .”).

I chalked it down almost immediately to men not being used to women occupying public spaces in the same way they do, in such closeness as the protest (like all protests) required.

As the day continued, the crowd became tired of an absent leadership, repeated calls by the police to comply and to stop the protest, and the sweatiness, discomfort and festering restlessness of a crowd of tens of thousands sequestered into less than half a kilometre of a cordoned off piece of road. Me and my (female) friends pushed our way to the front, where in all our enthusiasm we reached right where the barricades and Rapid Action Forces separated the protest site from the city outside it. I tried to push, break, and holler at them with other men, but eventually a few kindly told me, “ Ma’am app dab jao ke bheed mai, aap idhar mat aao. ” (“ Ma’am, don’t come into the crowd, you’ll get crushed .”)

These men tried to convince my friends to go to the sides of the Jantar Mantar protest site, next to “a wall near a park”. In the meantime, the protest had gotten sweaty, dehydrating, and suffocating. One person fainted in front of us, and we gave him water before his friends carried him away (hopefully to a spot with less of a crowd). The mostly male crowd at the barricades from where we’d been sidelined was tired and angry. Some of these well-meaning men thought that the best use of their time in a protest against NEET paper leaks and for a better, more just education system, would be to “help” women jump over the aforementioned wall so they could be somewhere with “less heat, less crowd”, whether they wanted to be or not.

As we refused , a few men pushed us to the wall and vehemently started explaining why we should go to the other side. Our explanation that we would much rather be in the suffocating crowd wasn’t enough, these men were so very worried that we’d get injured or harassed within the crowd, that they thought it imminent to harass and injure us themselves.

As if things weren’t bad enough, I saw that the electric wires lining the wall’s fence were giving shocks to the men and women trying to jump it. Luckily, I was able to use that as an excuse to escape my well-meaning tormentors. Then, me and my friends found other groups of women to push through the crowds with, and stick as much as possible, with groups of women throughout, as we pushed across not one, not two, but three rows of police barricades layered across short distances.

I’ve already narrated the police brutality that we faced. Now let me focus on the searing brutality of the everyday-variety of patriarchy I encountered from the male protesters.

Example one has been narrated above, now for example two: A comment I heard a random man make to his friend as we were standing in the crowd near him. “ Kisi ki ladki ko kuch hona nahi chahiye. ” (“ Nothing should happen to anyone’s girl here. ”)

This made me furious. Here I was, labouring under the delusion that, being an adult and an emancipated woman, my fellow protesters saw me as human. But no, I was in the basest expression of patriarchy, “someone’s” ladki (I assume daughter/wife/sister-adjacent) to a significant portion of the swathes of men around me. I was to be “protected” only as someone else’s property. Not a person, not a human, not an independent being, not a comrade standing for the same cause: a woman defined in my relationship to men.

Then there was this elderly Sikh uncle. Barricade number 4, after the lathi-charge and the near death stampede: We had convinced the crowd to let the women at the front, since we could see more female cops at the front, whom we’d be better equipped to stand against.

It worked. The crowd made way for me and the women with me.

I wanted to scream to these men that I am an equal citizen, that I have been to a hell of a lot more of these protests here than them (bet?), and that I (or any other woman here) can handle myself.

This “protectionist” streak that ran within the male protesters’ rhetoric that entire day (and yes, I am generalising though there were tens of thousands or more protesters; enough of them wanted to sideline the women quite physically that the generalisation is justified) is blatantly patriarchal. For the first time, I was made to feel by these comments and these actions, that I do not belong protesting at Jantar Mantar. Not with a huge number of men there, too.

I also felt the distinct sexualisation in their (the men’s) verbal reminders to each other not to sexualise the women there. There were many men saying, screaming, asserting that they wouldn’t “let” any other protestor harass the women there. Funny, since these statements itself seemed to be harassment; seemed to be a reminder that we aren’t free of the constant anxiety of being groped, molested, or abducted here, it is just that for this moment , these few hours , these men have deigned not to hurt us. And in loudly proclaiming that they won’t, they are also proclaiming that they can.

Further, and perhaps the most violent infliction of patriarchy I felt at the protest (and I have by no means exhausted all my examples, it’s just too tiring to write any more) was when this man, once I was separated from my friends and ended up crushed underneath two bikes (fallen on me from two different directions as a result of the aforementioned lathi-charge induced stampede), who just stared at me. He had an almost-threatening expression to his face. As the police lathi-charged people around him and I tried to wiggle myself away from the crushing weight of the bikes, I stopped to stare back, wondering why the man is not running from the ongoing lathi charge like the others, or coming to help me, as a decent person would. Instead, he’s just standing in the middle of an active lathi charge, cops beating people around him, taking action neither to save himself or others, just staring. At me.

Later, a few of us marching women ended up detained at the aforementioned Bank post lathi-charge. There, this same man (also, sequestered there with other “detainees”) came up to me and said, in a deadpan tone of voice, “ Akeli ladkiyon ko protest mai nahi aana chahiye. ” (“Lone women should not come to a protest.”)

I didn’t bother to respond.

The benevolent patriarchy of all the men at the protest faded away into oblivion in that moment. I saw all of it together as this one monolithian, morally-policing, verbally violent statement of this strange man: How dare you occupy a public space shoulder to shoulder with men?

How dare you stand on ground where we, as men, don’t get to dictate the terms of your existence?

I can “understand” where a lot of this patriarchy is coming from: a society where men and women never occupy any public space as equal participants, where men know that from buses to metros to trains to streets to societies to shops to markets to homes to factories to farms to graveyards to ghats , every place is one where a woman (known or unknown to the perpetrator(s)) can be routinely be subjected to violence, sexual and physical. They know that these spaces belong to them, and that women may even be scarce in many of them [and when women do, out of necessity or defiance, occupy these spaces- they make sure, by words or by action that we realise that we don’t belong and fear trying to belong]. This patriarchy in its benevolent form, is reflected in their urge to “protect” women and hence, police their access to these spaces (all spaces), and enforces the idea that women can/should either not frequent them, or if they do, should do so on terms dictated by men (in appropriate clothes, with an appropriate number of people, perhaps with a male companion.... The list of what women “should” do never ends).

The men at the protest tried to dictate the terms for us, to “protect” us by keeping us “away”, but they only ended up marginalising and hurting us further. As a result of happenstance at birth, those socialised as women grow up feeling that they don’t belong, and society reinforces that feeling in them everyday, through overt violence and silently accepted and followed social codes. These men, strangers to us, by asserting and attempting to negotiate how WE, as female protestors, should navigate the March, subjected us to patriarchy. An experience of patriarchy that left me feeling that I, indeed, don’t belong here.

One of my favourite quotes of all time, unattributed and anonymous like the best of them, has been, “A woman’s home is the revolution, because she has no other place to go.” The CJP protest was definitively not a revolution, but it did succeed in disenfranchising me further from resistance, by making me feel I don’t belong to the one place I’ve frequented for 3 years now: the Jantar Mantar protest site.



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